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Lata Mangeshkar

Early Life

Lata Mangeshkar was born on **28 September 1929** in Indore, then the capital of the princely state of Indore (present-day Madhya Pradesh), which was part of the Central India Agency in British India.

Her father, **Deenanath Mangeshkar**, was a Marathi and Konkani classical singer and theatre actor. Deenanath's father, Ganesh Bhatt Bhikoba Navathe Hardikar (Abhisheki), a Karhade Brahmin, served as a priest at the famous Mangeshi Temple in Goa. His mistress, **Yesubai**, belonged to the Devadasi community of Goa, known for its matrilineal traditions and temple artistry. She was also a reputed musician. Deenanath adopted the surname *Mangeshkar* from his ancestral village, Mangeshi, in Goa.

Lata's mother, **Shevanti (later renamed Shudhamati)**, was from Thalner in the Bombay Presidency (now in Maharashtra). She was Deenanath's second wife; his first wife, Narmada (Shevanti's elder sister), had passed away earlier. Lata's maternal grandfather, Seth Haridas Ramdas Lad, was a prosperous businessman and landlord in Thalner. From her maternal grandmother, Lata learned Gujarati folk songs such as the *garbas* of Pavagadh.

Career

In **1942**, when Lata was just 13, her father passed away due to heart disease. The family's close friend, **Master Vinayak (Vinayak Damodar Karnataki)**, owner of Navyug Chitrapat film company, took care of the Mangeshkar family and helped young Lata begin her career.

Her first song was "*Naachu Yaa Gade, Khelu Saari Mani Haus Bhaari*" for the Marathi film *Kiti Hasaal* (1942), but it was later dropped. The same year, she sang "*Natali Chaitraachi Navalaa*" in the Marathi film *Pahili Mangalaa-Gaur* (1942). Her first Hindi song was "*Mata Ek Sapoot Ki Duniya Badal De Tu*" from the film *Gajaabhaau* (1943).

Although she initially had to act in films due to financial needs, she disliked acting. Her real breakthrough came in **1949** with the song "*Aayega Aanevala*" from the film *Mahal*, composed by Khemchand Prakash and picturized on Madhubala. The song's popularity marked the rise of playback singers in Indian cinema, giving them recognition beyond anonymity.

From the late 1940s, Lata became the voice of several generations of heroines in Indian cinema. She sang in **over 36 Indian languages** and a few foreign languages, though her primary work was in **Hindi, Marathi, and Bengali**.

Achievements and Awards

Lata Mangeshkar's illustrious career was decorated with numerous awards and honors:

- **Bharat Ratna** (2001) – India's highest civilian award, making her only the second singer to receive it.
- **Padma Bhushan** (1969) and **Padma Vibhushan** (1999).
- **Dadasaheb Phalke Award** (1989).
- **Maharashtra Bhushan Award** (1997).
- **NTR National Award** (1999).
- **ANR National Award** (2009).
- **Legion of Honour (Officer rank)** – France's highest civilian award (2009).
- **Three National Film Awards**.
- **15 Bengal Film Journalists' Association Awards**.

Four Filmfare Best Female Playback Awards, before voluntarily stepping aside in 1969 to promote new talent. She later received two **Filmfare Special Awards** (1994, 2004) and the **Filmfare Lifetime Achievement Award** (1993).

In **1974**, she became the first Indian playback singer to perform at the **Royal Albert Hall, London**.

Several state governments also instituted awards in her honor, including the **Lata Mangeshkar Award** by Madhya Pradesh (1984) and Maharashtra (1992).

She was included in the **Guinness World Records** as the most recorded artist in history until her sister Asha Bhosle later surpassed her.

In 2012, she was ranked No. 10 in *Outlook India's* poll of the *Greatest Indian Since Independence*. In 2023, she was placed at **84th in Rolling Stone's list of the 200 Greatest Singers of All Time**.

She also received honorary doctorates from:

- **Sangeet Natak Akademi** (1989),
- **Indira Kala Sangeet Vishwavidyalaya, Khairagarh,**
- **Shivaji University, Kolhapur,**
- **York University, Toronto.**

Legacy

Ustad Bade Ghulam Ali Khan once said of her: “*Kambakht, kabhi besuri na hoti*” (She never goes out of tune). Actor Dilip Kumar described her voice as “*a miracle from God*”.

In 2022, Lata Mangeshkar was honored in the *In Memoriam* segment at the **BAFTA Awards**. She remains an eternal voice in Indian music, remembered not only for her unmatched talent but also for her dedication, humility, and contribution to the nation’s cultural heritage.